PRACTICE EXAM 1 OF 4 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

Practice exam 1

Twenty questions across all three domains, in exam proportions, with a walkthrough after each one and a scoring guide at the end.

QUESTIONS 20 PEOPLE 7 PROCESS 8 BUS ENV 5

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How to take this exam

- Each question holds on screen for a few seconds after it is read. **Choose within that time**, or pause if you need to.
- **Write down your letter** before the answer is shown. No changing it afterwards.
- No notes and no rewinding. Treat it as the real thing.
- Use the method: approach, problem, call, eliminate, ladder.
- At the end, score yourself by domain, not just in total.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Commit before you see the answer. A walkthrough you watch without committing teaches far less.

> An agile team has a new developer who joined from an organisation with a very hierarchical culture. In three retrospectives, he has not said a word, although his colleagues say he has good ideas.
>
> The scrum master wants his contribution.

What should the scrum master do?

A Talk with him privately, and use retrospective formats that start with silent, written ideas before discussion.

B Ask him directly for his views in front of the team at the next retrospective.

C Leave him alone; he will speak when he is ready.

D Ask his manager to encourage him to participate more.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the scrum master do?

A Private talk; silent-first formats.
Builds safety and gives him a way in that fits his background.

B Put him on the spot.
Likely to deepen the discomfort a hierarchical background creates.

C Leave him alone.
The team loses his ideas, and nothing changes.

D Ask his manager.
Turns a team matter into a management one; adds pressure, not safety.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. Psychological safety and cultural awareness: create safe ways in, don't force.

> On a predictive construction project, the monthly report shows a cost performance index of 1.15 and a schedule performance index of 0.85.
>
> The sponsor is pleased that the project is under budget.

What is the most accurate interpretation?

A The project is performing well on both cost and schedule.

B The project is over budget and behind schedule.

C The work done has cost less than planned, but the project is behind schedule, so the saving may partly reflect work not yet started.

D The project is ahead of schedule, which explains the low cost.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the most accurate interpretation?

A Good on both.
SPI 0.85 is well behind schedule.

B Over and behind.
CPI above 1 means under budget for the work done.

C Efficient on cost, behind on time.
Reads both indices correctly and questions the saving.

D Ahead of schedule.
SPI below 1 means behind, not ahead.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. CPI above 1 is good; SPI below 1 is bad. Read both, and ask what links them.

> Two days before a public website release, testers find that key booking pages cannot be used with a screen reader. The organisation is legally required to meet an accessibility standard.
>
> The product owner wants to release on time and fix it later.

What should the project manager do?

A Release on time, as the product owner prefers, and log the defect.

B Remove the accessibility tests from the definition of done for this release.

C Delay the entire release indefinitely until every page is perfect.

D Explain the legal obligation to the product owner, and agree with compliance a way to release only compliant pages or fix them first.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Release and log it.
Knowingly releases a legal non-compliance.

B Drop the tests.
Hides a compliance failure by removing the check.

C Delay indefinitely.
Overreacts; a compliant partial release or quick fix may be possible.

D Explain; agree a compliant path.
Compliance is not negotiable, but the route to it can be.

THE SIGNAL

Business Environment domain. A legal requirement is not traded for a date; the approach to meeting it is.

> Midway through a sprint, a senior stakeholder asks a developer to add a new report. Doing it would put the sprint goal at risk.
>
> The developer asks the scrum master what to do.

What should happen?

A The developer adds the report, since the stakeholder is senior.

B The request goes to the product owner to add to the product backlog, protecting the current sprint goal.

C The sprint is cancelled so the report can be built.

D The scrum master rejects the request outright.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should happen?

A Just add it.

Endangers the sprint goal and bypasses the product owner.

B To the product owner and backlog.

Protects the sprint and lets the owner order the request.

C Cancel the sprint.

Only the product owner can, and only if the goal becomes obsolete.

D Reject it.

The request may be valuable. It deserves ordering, not refusal.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Mid-sprint requests go to the product owner and the backlog. The sprint goal is protected.

> On a predictive project, two specialists each believe the other is accountable for validating migrated data. Validation has not been done, and the RACI chart lists both as 'responsible' but nobody as 'accountable'.
>
> Testing starts next week.

What should the project manager do?

A Clarify the roles with both specialists, name one person accountable, and update the RACI chart.

B Do the data validation personally to avoid delay.

C Ask both specialists' managers to decide between them.

D Make both specialists jointly accountable for the task.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Clarify; one accountable; update RACI.

Fixes the root cause: an unclear role, with one name accountable.

B Do it personally.

Solves this instance; the role gap remains.

C Ask their managers.

Escalates a gap the PM can clarify directly.

D Joint accountability.

A RACI needs exactly one accountable person. Joint means neither.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. One task, exactly one accountable person. A gap in the RACI is fixed with the team.

> A usually reliable team member on a hybrid project has been working late every night for three weeks. Her work now has errors, and she seems exhausted and short-tempered in meetings.
>
> She has not raised any problem.

What should the project manager do?

A. Point out the errors in the next team meeting so they are corrected.

B. Report her performance to her functional manager.

C. Talk with her privately and supportively, understand what is driving the workload, and rebalance it.

D. Wait until the next performance review to discuss it.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Raise errors in the meeting.
Public criticism of an exhausted person worsens things.

B Report to her manager.
Treats a wellbeing and workload problem as a conduct problem.

C Private, supportive talk; rebalance.
Emotional intelligence: find the cause and remove it.

D Wait for the review.
Leaves a burnout risk to grow for weeks.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. A reliable person's sudden change is a signal. Talk privately, find the cause, fix the load.

> A supplier on a firm fixed price contract writes that its home currency has fallen sharply, and asks for a 15 percent price increase. The contract has no economic price adjustment clause.
>
> The supplier hints that it may struggle to deliver without the increase.

What should the project manager do?

A Agree the increase to keep the supplier happy.

B Review the contract terms with procurement, assess the risk of supplier failure, and negotiate from there.

C Terminate the contract immediately for threatening non-delivery.

D Ignore the letter, since the price is fixed.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Agree the increase.

Gives away the protection the fixed price was bought for, without analysis.

B Review terms; assess risk; negotiate.

Holds the contract position while facing the real risk of supplier failure.

C Terminate.

Drastic, and may leave the project with no supplier at all.

D Ignore it.

The price is fixed, but the delivery risk is real and needs managing.

THE SIGNAL

Business Environment domain. External shock plus a contract: know the terms, weigh the risk, then negotiate.

> A junior developer on an agile team consistently underestimates his stories, and often needs to carry work into the next sprint. He is keen to improve.
>
> The rest of the team estimates well.

What is the best action for the scrum master?

A Stop him from estimating, and let senior developers estimate for him.

B Add 50 percent to every estimate he gives.

C Coach him, for example by pairing him with a senior developer and reviewing his estimates against actuals together.

D Raise his performance with the functional manager.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What is the best action for the scrum master?

A Stop him estimating.
Removes the learning, and his voice from planning poker.

B Pad his estimates.
Hides the problem instead of building the skill.

C Coach, pair, compare with actuals.
Builds the skill of a willing learner using his own history.

D Go to his manager.
Treats a development need as a performance problem.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. A willing learner with a skills gap needs coaching, not workarounds or reporting.

> On a predictive manufacturing project, the customer's acceptance inspections have rejected three batches for defects that the team's own quality control had passed.
>
> The team's inspectors say they followed the procedure.

What should the project manager do first?

A Review the quality control process, for example with an audit, and find the root cause of the missed defects.

B Add a second round of the same inspection.

C Replace the inspectors.

D Ask the customer to relax its acceptance criteria.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Audit the process; find the root cause.
If the procedure was followed, the procedure itself may be the problem.

B Inspect twice.
Repeating a flawed inspection repeats the miss.

C Replace inspectors.
Blames people who followed the procedure.

D Relax the criteria.
Lowers quality to hide the defects.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Procedure followed but defects missed: the process is the suspect. Audit it.

> On a predictive project, a regional director with approval authority over design decisions regularly replies to approval emails days after the deadline, delaying work.
>
> Other stakeholders respond on time.

What should the project manager do?

A Send more frequent reminder emails.

B Treat missed deadlines as approval.

C Escalate the delays to the sponsor.

D Meet the director to understand how she prefers to engage, and agree an approach, such as short decision calls or a delegate.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A More reminders.

More of the channel that is already failing.

B Silence as approval.

Assumes authority the PM does not have; risky and unfair.

C Escalate.

Premature. Nobody has asked her what would work.

D Meet; agree how she engages.

Tailors communication to the stakeholder's needs and constraints.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. When a channel keeps failing for one stakeholder, ask what works for them.

> A product owner wants to hold back an app's first release until all planned features are complete, in about five months. A smaller set of features, already done and tested, would solve customers' most common problem now.
>
> Customers have been asking for exactly that.

What should the project leader do?

A Support the product owner's decision without comment.

B Discuss with the product owner releasing the completed, valuable features now, to deliver value and gather feedback sooner.

C Release the features without the product owner's agreement.

D Escalate the release decision to the sponsor.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Stay silent.

Leaves five months of available value on the table without discussion.

B Discuss an early release with the PO.

Raises the value case with the person who owns the decision.

C Release anyway.

Overrides the product owner's authority.

D Escalate.

Premature; the product owner has not heard the case yet.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Finished, valuable work waiting months: make the case for releasing it, to its owner.

> During a hybrid project, a developer notices that an open-source library the product depends on has announced it will stop being maintained in six months.
>
> It is not in the risk register.

What should happen next?

A Replace the library immediately.

B Ignore it, since the library still works.

C Record it as a risk, analyse its impact, assign an owner, and plan a response.

D Escalate it to the sponsor as an issue.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should happen next?

A Replace it now.

A major change before analysing impact or options.

B Ignore it.

Unmaintained code becomes a security and support risk.

C Record, analyse, own, respond.

A new risk goes into the register and through the risk process.

D Escalate as an issue.

It has not happened yet, and it is within the project's authority.

THE SIGNAL

Business Environment domain. A newly spotted future problem is a risk. Register, analyse, own, respond.

> On a predictive project, a supplier submits an invoice for a milestone payment. The contract says milestone payments are due on formal acceptance, and the deliverable has not yet passed acceptance testing.
>
> The supplier says it has done the work.

What should the project manager do?

A Check the invoice against the contract's acceptance terms, and pay only when the milestone is accepted, explaining this to the supplier.

B Pay the invoice to keep a good relationship.

C Pay half now and half on acceptance.

D Reject the invoice and stop communicating until testing is complete.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Pay on acceptance, per the contract; explain.
Follows the agreed terms, and keeps the relationship clear.

B Pay anyway.
Gives up the leverage the payment terms were designed to provide.

C Pay half.
Invents terms the contract does not contain.

D Reject and go silent.
Right on payment, wrong on the relationship.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Payment follows the contract's acceptance terms. Explain it; do not improvise.

> Several agile team members complain privately that one colleague often misses the daily meeting and does not finish work he commits to. The team's morale is suffering.
>
> The colleague is well liked and technically strong.

What should the scrum master do?

A Report the colleague to his functional manager.

B Ignore it, since he is technically strong.

C Raise his behaviour by name at the next daily meeting.

D Talk with him privately to understand what is happening, and help the team revisit its working agreement.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the scrum master do?

A Report him.
Escalates before anyone has asked him why.

B Ignore it.
Morale is already suffering; it will get worse.

C Name him in the meeting.
Public blame damages trust for everyone.

D Private conversation; revisit the working agreement.
Finds the cause, and lets the team own its norms.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. Private first to understand; then the team's own agreement sets the standard.

> A predictive project will use a technology the organisation has never used before. The sponsor wants a single, firm cost figure for the business case next week.
>
> There is no historical data, and the team is unsure how long the integration will take.

What should the project manager provide?

A. A single figure, as requested, based on the team's best guess.

B. A range, with its assumptions, and a plan to narrow it quickly, for example through a prototype.

C. A very high figure to be safe.

D. No estimate until the design is complete.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager provide?

A One firm figure.
False precision; the sponsor would treat a guess as a commitment.

B A range, assumptions, and a plan to narrow it.
Honest about uncertainty, and useful for the business case.

C A padded figure.
Hidden padding distorts the business case.

D Nothing yet.
The sponsor needs something to decide with now.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. High uncertainty: an honest range with assumptions, plus a plan to reduce it.

> In an organisation with four agile teams, the same kind of security defect has appeared in releases from three of them over two months. Each team fixed its own instance separately.
>
> The teams rarely talk to each other.

What should the project leader recommend?

A Ask each team to add more security testing on its own.

B Appoint one person to check every release for this defect.

C Share the lesson across teams, for example through a community of practice, and update the shared definition of done and standards.

D Record the defects in each team's lessons learned register.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader recommend?

A Each team tests more alone.
Four separate fixes for one shared cause.

B One checker for all.
Inspection bottleneck; does not prevent the defect.

C Share across teams; update shared standards.
Turns one lesson into an organisational asset, preventing it everywhere.

D Record it in each register.
Records the lesson; does not spread or apply it.

THE SIGNAL

Business Environment domain. A lesson repeated across teams belongs in shared standards and assets.

> A hybrid project team works across London, Chicago and Singapore. The weekly planning meeting is at a time convenient for London and Chicago, which is 10 p.m. in Singapore.
>
> The Singapore members have begun missing it, and feel left out of decisions.

What should the project manager do?

A. Rotate the meeting time so the inconvenience is shared, and record decisions for asynchronous review.

B. Require the Singapore members to attend, since the time was agreed.

C. Hold the meeting without Singapore and email them the outcome.

D. Move all planning work to the Singapore team.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Rotate times; record for async review.
Shares the burden fairly and keeps everyone in decisions.

B Require attendance.
Keeps the unfair burden on one site.

C Meet without them.
Formalises the exclusion they already feel.

D Move planning to Singapore.
Shifts the problem to the other two sites.

THE SIGNAL

People domain. Distributed teams share the inconvenience, and design for asynchronous inclusion.

> A Kanban team's weekly throughput has ranged from 4 to 12 items over the last ten weeks. A stakeholder asks when 40 remaining items will be finished.
>
> The stakeholder wants a single date.

What should the project leader provide?

A. A single date based on the best week, 12 items.

B. A single date based on the worst week, 4 items.

C. No forecast, since Kanban does not use dates.

D. A forecast range based on the team's actual throughput history, with a likely date and a confidence level.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader provide?

A Best week.
Optimistic; almost certainly missed.

B Worst week.
Pessimistic; understates what the team normally does.

C No forecast.
Kanban teams forecast from throughput all the time.

D Range from history, with confidence.
Honest about variation, and still useful for planning.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Variable throughput: forecast a range from history, with a confidence level.

> The organisation announces a merger with a competitor. The competitor already has a customer app that does much of what a hybrid project is building.
>
> The project is six months from completion.

What should the project manager do?

A Continue as planned until told otherwise.

B Evaluate the impact with the sponsor, and revalidate the business case and priorities in light of the merger.

C Stop the project immediately, since the competitor's app exists.

D Speed up delivery so the project finishes before the merger completes.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Continue until told.

Keeps building something that may duplicate the merged company's app.

B Evaluate impact; revalidate with the sponsor.

An organisational change affects value; the owner decides with evidence.

C Stop now.

Not the PM's decision, and the merged strategy may still need parts of it.

D Rush to finish.

Racing to complete possibly duplicate work adds cost and risk.

THE SIGNAL

Business Environment domain. An organisational change that affects value goes to the sponsor, with analysis.

> On a predictive project, the change control board approved a change adding a new feature, with extra cost and two weeks. The team updated the schedule baseline and started work.
>
> The cost baseline and the requirements traceability matrix were not updated.

What should the project manager do?

A Leave the cost baseline as it is, since the schedule was updated.

B Submit a new change request for the cost.

C Report the project as over budget at the next review.

D Update the cost baseline and all other affected documents to reflect the approved change.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Leave the cost baseline.

Performance will be measured against a baseline that is wrong.

B A new change request.

The cost was already approved as part of the same change.

C Report as over budget.

A reporting error caused by the missing update, not a real overrun.

D Update all affected baselines and documents.

An approved change is finished only when every document reflects it.

THE SIGNAL

Process domain. Integration: one approved change updates every affected baseline and document.

Scoring guide

DOMAIN	QUESTIONS	YOUR SCORE
People	1, 5, 6, 8, 10, 14, 17	out of 7
Process	2, 4, 9, 11, 13, 15, 18, 20	out of 8
Business Environment	3, 7, 12, 16, 19	out of 5
Total	20 questions	out of 20

ON THE EXAM

Which domain your misses cluster in matters more than the total. PMI publishes no pass mark; aim for consistency.

What to do with your result

- **Around 16 or more**: strong. Keep practising with the next exam.
- **Around 13 to 15**: close. Revisit the modules named in the walkthroughs you missed.
- **Below 13**: rewatch the modules for your weakest domain before the next exam.
- For every miss, name the distractor pattern you fell for. Patterns repeat.
- These bands are a study guide, not PMI's standard, which is not published.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Name the pattern behind each miss. That is what carries into the next exam.

Score by domain. Name each miss's pattern. Then take exam 2.